

SADDLING UP Mumbai Police personnel patrolling on horseback at Juhu Beach in Mumbai, Sept. 2020

MANDAR DEODHAR

MUMBAI POLICE

RETURN OF HORSEPOWER

Additionally, horses can enter and navigate areas where vehicles cannot be deployed.

Horses have been used in the force since its genesis as the 'Bhandari Militia' in 1669. The officers and men of the later-day Bombay City Police used these mounts for travel, law-and-order measures and patrolling.

In 2018, the then commissioner of police Subodh Kumar Jaiswal sent a proposal to the state government for the revival of the mounted police unit. This was eventually implemented in January 2020, with 13 horses, including seven thoroughbreds retired from racing and six Kathiawaris donated by a corporate-run foundation. The fleet of horses was kept in a temporary facility at Marol. Around 25 men were trained at the racecourses in Mumbai and Pune, and with the Kolkata Police. The riders were given a designer uniform and Maratha-style headgear.

However, the Covid pandemic affected the deployment of the unit, and some of the horses passed away. Currently, the police have six horses, four of which are kept at the Maharashtra Police Academy in Nashik. Eventually, the unit was discontinued in 2022.

A senior police officer says that a lack of experience in raising and operating a mounted unit affected their previous attempt at reviving it. "Our budgets for purchasing horses were low... the youngest horse we acquired was around nine years old and the oldest was 12. Budgetary constraints prevented us from matching the unique and expensive diet, including supplements, that racehorses are accustomed to," he explains. The recurring expenses for their upkeep were also high. Learning from their mistakes, the official adds, they addressed these issues in the new proposal that was sent out to the Maharashtra government.

The mounted unit has a sanctioned strength of 30 thoroughbred horses (including the six already in service) to be inducted in batches of 10 horses per year. The senior official quoted earlier says they hope to induct the first batch of five horses by the end of the year and reach full strength in about three years.

The stables at Marol will be developed in two phases, with a capacity for 20 and 10 horses in each phase. The facility will also include a training ground, a sandpit as well as areas for storing hay and fodder. Around 40 men will be trained in handling horses, managing the stables and in mounted patrolling. The officer highlights that states like Gujarat, Kerala, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu and Telangana have mounted police units.

Deepak Rao, a historian of the Mumbai Police, underlines how the mounted police served a useful purpose in the past. "Trained men and horses are effective in handling crowds and dispersing mobs. Two trained men on horseback can achieve what 20 men on the ground can do. A few riders moving in formation around a mob can have a salutary effect," he notes.

However, a retired police officer points out that deploying horses on concretised roads would be difficult for them. Similarly, deploying them in locations far from their stables in Marol means that they have to be transported back and forth in special vans. "Mumbai's streets have no place for pedestrians to walk on. How can horses navigate them? What if a horse goes berserk in the crowd?" he asks. For the moment, though, the arrival of these proud steeds is eagerly awaited. ■

FLASHBACK

- **Commissioners of police moved around on horseback before H.G. Gell (1902-09) became the first one to use a motor car (1907)**
- **When the commissioner's office was opened opposite Crawford Market in 1899, it had a stable**
- **During the tenure of Sir Patrick Kelly (commissioner, 1922-33), the mounted units were used to tackle the notorious Pathan gangs**